Indian diaspora, did not even know something as historic as the Yatra was happening.

The message of the Yatra was simple—that politics should not be the agenda of polarization, hatred and antagonism, lies and winning elections at all costs. Rather, politics and government should be about compassion, solidarity and bringing people together. As Rahul said, '*Hum nafrat ke bazaar mein, mohabbat ki dukaan kholney aaye hain* (In a marketplace of hate, we have come to open a shop of love).' This message was not lost on his audience, which has been witness to India being driven by the politics of hate, the hounding of religious minorities, misogyny, violence against low-caste citizens and national chauvinism taken to absurd limits, all of which are now part of a supremacist Hindutva ideology.

This Yatra was organized by the Indian National Congress, a party that Rahul Gandhi's family has long dominated. When it started on 7 September 2022, with a planned conclusion on 26 January 2023, India's Republic Day, not many expected it to last the whole way. But the march only grew in numbers as the yatris passed through eight of India's twenty-eight states. The Central government even threatened to stop it citing fears of Covid, even while Prime Minister Modi himself continued to address rallies.

Each day began at 6 a.m. In Rajasthan, in December, this meant it was pitch dark and bitterly cold. As we huddled in our shawls and jackets, our bodies warmed with the chants and slogans that began as soon as we set off. '*Jodo jodo, Bharat Jodo* (Unite India, unite India)', '*Nafrat chhodo, Bharat jodo* (Leave hate, unite India)', '*Prem se bolo, Bharat jodo* (Hail it lovingly, unite India)'. The improvisations were many and frequent, and we were exhorted to join in. Anyone who has been in a demonstration will recognize the feeling that chanting in unison with others, adding your own voice to a collective roar, is a powerful tonic and generates what the sociologist Émile Durkheim calls 'collective effervescence'. This was made all the more powerful when those lining the route also joined in.

The first comfort break typically came around 8.30 a.m. for a few minutes when anyone who wanted tea could grab a quick one at a roadside stall. But we continued on, taking the first major break of the day at 10.30